Brokers Who Do Not Bridge: When Assessment, Not Access, Shapes Broker Advantage

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Abstract

Structural theories describe economic brokerage as an opportune but fragile position bridging gaps between otherwise disconnected actors. In that view, brokering can undermine trust or eliminate the gaps that generate its value, and brokers need supporting institutions or deeper interpersonal ties to stabilize their role. Yet many corporate actors in positions of brokerage, from Visa to TP ICAP, have gained market power, increased profitability, or grown in prominence even as networks transformed around them. When can brokering strengthen rather than undermine a broker's advantage?

I reconceptualize brokerage as outsourced relational work, in which a broker who assumes no inventory risk constructs viable matches between parties who cannot easily find or evaluate one another. Repeated matchmaking generates an informational byproduct that, after the digital turn, the corporate broker can accumulate at scale: knowledge of what makes pairings successful across the market, unavailable to clients who observe only their own dealings. And in the age of machine learning, this data can be mined for predictions of the value of potential matches. An agent-based model of a matching market identifies conditions under which this informational advantage emerges and persists. Brokerage can provide assessment rather than access: clients outsource matching even when they can reach counterparties themselves, because the broker's predictions are valuable. Counterintuitively, the broker can become highly central in regimes where it engages in little bridging behavior: broker centrality is a product, not a primary source, of matchmaking quality.

While the model explores the dynamics of the broker's informational advantage, I theorize how this advantage can then enable the broker to become a principal selling the resource it once intermediated or monetizing data and analytics. This is *transient brokerage*, a process in which brokering becomes secondary or ceases because of the broker's power rather than its fragility. The argument provides microfoundations for understanding the new dynamics of economic intermediation in the age of AI and big data.

I Introduction

Intermediation in economic relations—the intervention of a third party to mediate or facilitate exchange between others—can take many forms. Brokerage is one of them. In markets, brokers are intermediaries that do not assume inventory risk: they act as matchmakers, connecting others.

Brokerage is pervasive in a wide variety of markets and remarkably persistent across time and space. Brokers find themselves in an advantageous but delicate position. In structural accounts, brokers need to stand between disconnected others to have the opportunity to broker, but through their work, they densify the networks around them, potentially eroding their own advantage. Unlike dealers and wholesalers, brokers do not maintain an inventory that they need to manage and can liquidate in case of difficulty. Unlike market makers, they keep offers and price information private (Rust and Hall 2003). They operate at the intersection of social groups (Burt 1992, 2004) and rely on secret information. As a result, they often lose the trust and legitimacy needed to continue their

activities. Prominent theories of brokerage have described it as an inherently fragile role that often gets "stabilized" to avoid collapsing, through the social isolation of brokers, their organizational grafting, or their capture by one side (Stovel, Golub, and Milgrom 2011).

If that is the case, then how have so many corporate actors in positions of brokerage, from Visa to TP ICAP, gained market power, increased profitability, or grown in prominence even as networks have changed around them?

Recent work by Ronald S. Burt, building on the tradition of structural-hole brokerage theory, has shown how many bridging ties are not weak or fragile, but rather strong high-trust ties forged through interpersonal history, which provide a robust and enduring advantage to the broker who relies on them (Burt 2026; Burt and Opper 2026). However, this is not the full story of broker strength.

Some brokers leverage their role to become principals rather than remain only intermediaries. They stabilize their advantage while their brokering work becomes secondary or even stops entirely. I call this *transient brokerage*, a phenomenon that current theories of brokerage do not satisfactorily predict or explain. Brokering sometimes declines or disappears because of the broker's power, not its fragility. This article explains under what conditions this happens.

This article redefines brokerage as *outsourced relational work*: the broker constructs viable matches between parties who cannot easily find or evaluate each other. This relational work generates an informational byproduct that the broker can leverage. While structural position can provide access to feed learning, each successful match between previously unconnected parties can erode the broker's structural advantage by densifying the network (Burt 2000, p. 356), but it also helps the broker accumulate knowledge of what makes pairings successful. In that way, the broker converts structural capital into informational capital through the act of brokering. This is particularly true for corporate brokers, who operate at scale and benefit from the legal privileges of the corporate form.

The digital turn further extends the scale at which this informational byproduct can be recorded, retained, and pooled across clients. Machine learning allows brokers to use those records to predict the value of potential matches. Accumulated relational work can become an input both to continued intermediation and to products sold separately as predictions or analytics.

This article develops a theory of brokerage as outsourced relational work and explains how the resulting informational advantage can be used by the broker to enable a transition from intermediary to principal. The article addresses three questions about brokerage:

(i) What value does a broker provide?

(ii) How does brokering alter a broker's informational and structural position?

(iii) Under what conditions can the broker convert its advantage to become a principal?

I develop an agent-based model (ABM) of brokerage in a general matching market to formalize the basis for the theory and illustrate how brokers shape and sustain structural and informational advantages through repeated matchmaking. The simulations show how several simple elements interact to produce non-obvious dynamics, complicating the expectation that brokers densify networks around them and erode their own position, and producing propositions for future empirical research. The ABM results suggest that brokerage can provide assessment rather than access, and that clients may continue outsourcing even when they can reach counterparties themselves. An experiment separating the two services shows that assessment becomes more valuable to principals as the value they derive from a match depends more on complementarity, or how well two parties fit together. When market participants leave and are replaced by new entrants at a high rate, the broker's provision of broader counterparty access becomes more valuable.

The broker ranks potential matches better than its clients. This assessment advantage comes from the information generated through its relational work. By pooling observations across clients, the broker learns how both parties' characteristics combine. By providing valuable assessments, the broker can sustain demand for its relational work, and that sustained use can increase its structural prominence. Bridging position is distinct from bridging behavior: a broker can be highly central while doing little or no bridging. The ABM results recast betweenness centrality not only as a source of brokerage opportunity, but also as a product of the kind and quality of a broker's relational work.

I build on these results to theorize how brokers can turn data obtained through their activity into a business more profitable than intermediation itself. Depending on the market in which the broker operates, the nature of the matching problem, and the relations between the actors involved, the broker can leverage its informational advantage to convert relational work done on behalf of others into personal economic advantage. When successful, **the broker becomes a principal**. With the necessary corporate infrastructure to support this transition, the broker can sell its assessment capability directly, by providing predictions or analytics services (**data enclosure**). It can also use that capability on its own behalf to strategically acquire the resource it once intermediated (**resource capture**) and resell, lease, or license it. This explains the rise in prominence of some firms acting as brokers.

The rest of this article proceeds as follows. Section II reviews structural and processual theories of brokerage and their blind spots. Section III reconceptualizes brokerage as outsourced relational work and traces how this work is transformed when performed at scale by corporate actors. Section IV presents the ABM and its results illustrating how a broker produces and sustains its advantage through this work. Section V builds on this foundation to theorize one possible trajectory that can follow from the broker advantage, transient brokerage, under which a broker can become a principal. Section VI discusses scope conditions and implications for the political economy of corporate intermediation, and Section VII concludes.

II Theories of Brokerage and Their Blind Spots

In markets where information is scarce or complex, participants are few, transactions are intricate, or institutions are poorly developed (Stovel, Golub, and Milgrom 2011), participants tend to seek the help of third parties to facilitate their transactions. Economic brokerage thus tends to emerge when counterparties are hard to find, resources hard to value, or transactions hard to structure, making intermediation work valuable. Real estate, mortgage, stock, and commodity markets are common examples of markets with many active brokers; so are markets for rare items and collectibles, over-the-counter financial markets, and many others.

Brokerage may also be helpful in circumstances where tight-knit, closed groups monopolize resources or information, and outsiders cannot easily access them (Stovel and Shaw 2012, p. 140). Brokerage can maintain or reinforce group boundaries, or it can blur or collapse them (Stovel and Shaw 2012), with consequences for social segregation, social integration, and relations between groups or communities (Galster and Godfrey 2005).

Past research has proposed two conflicting sets of definitions of brokerage (for a review, see Erikson 2013): formalist or structuralist definitions (Burt 1992; Gould and Fernandez 1989; Granovetter 1973; Marsden 1982), and broader processual definitions (Obstfeld, Borgatti, and Davis 2014; Rossman 2014; Spiro, Acton, and Butts 2013; Stovel and Shaw 2012).

A Formalist and Structuralist Definitions

Early brokerage research examined the structure of networks and the positions of actors to identify brokerage forms, categorize them, and determine their consequences (Burt 1992, 2004; Gould and

Fernandez 1989; Granovetter 1973; Marsden 1982; Simmel 1964, 1971). Brokerage opportunities arise when there are gaps in a social network, such that some nodes are close (in degrees of separation) yet disconnected (Burt 1992, 2004; Marsden 1982). Brokerage is synonymous with open triads or structural holes: a structure in which a third actor bridges two otherwise unconnected nodes. The third actor mediates flows of resources and information and facilitates transactions between others who lack access to one another (Fernandez and Gould 1994, p. 1457; Marsden 1982, p. 202). Researchers in this tradition generally set aside interactional content to achieve greater generality (Erikson 2013). For instance, Burt (1992, p. 36) was explicit in treating "motivation and opportunity as one and the same."

Burt (1992) operationalized the structural-hole concept, proposing the measures of network constraint and effective size to quantify how well positioned an actor is for brokerage, which allowed the theory to be tested across a wide range of settings. For instance, in a follow-up study, Burt (2004) investigated the network position of 673 managers in a large electronics company. He found that those who spanned structural holes generated ideas that senior management judged more valuable and were rewarded with better performance evaluations, promotions, and compensation. He suggested that brokers appear more creative because they can take insights that are commonplace in one group and introduce them to other people to whom they appear novel and original (Burt 2004, p. 388).

As such, brokers derive an advantage from their ability to exploit preexisting information in the network. Because of their position, brokers get privileged access to diverse ideas from across the network. They can see opportunities that others do not, and they can strategically use their position by providing or withholding information (Burt 1992) or using it to sustain their own creative endeavors. Exposed to varied perspectives, they are well-positioned to build a richer understanding, synthesize across domains or outlooks, and develop a unique vision (Burt 2004).

Defining brokerage based on structural holes, however, excludes situations that clearly appear as brokerage to a lay observer. For instance, Alice wants to sell her house and asks a real estate broker to list it. Soon after the real estate broker puts up the 'for sale' sign, Alice's neighbor Bob, whom Alice knows personally, contacts the broker to purchase the house. A broker intermediates the transaction, yet no structural hole existed between buyer and seller.

B Processual Definitions

More recently, some researchers have recast brokering as a set of relational processes (Obstfeld, Borgatti, and Davis 2014; Rossman 2014; Spiro, Acton, and Butts 2013; Stovel and Shaw 2012). Stovel and Shaw suggested that brokerage was "the process of connecting actors in systems of social, economic, or political relations in order to facilitate access to valued resources" (Stovel and Shaw 2012, p. 141; see also Stovel, Golub, and Milgrom 2011). Brokers exhibit two crucial features: they are positioned as bridges across gaps, and they help transfer resources or knowledge across those gaps (Stovel and Shaw 2012, p. 141). This definition remains constrained by social structure but requires brokerage behavior. Hence, there can be structural holes without brokerage—some bridging actors do not transmit anything across holes—but no brokerage without structural holes. In this way, it runs into the same conceptual problem as purely structural definitions.

Obstfeld, Borgatti, and Davis (2014), building on Marsden (1982), proposed a purely processual definition: brokerage is a process by which an actor "alters interaction between two or more parties in a wide variety of triadic structures" (Obstfeld, Borgatti, and Davis 2014, p. 136), meaning that he "influences, manages, or facilitates" the interaction (Obstfeld, Borgatti, and Davis 2014, p. 141). This eliminates any structural requirement beyond the need for three or more actors. It is no longer necessary for the alters to lack access to or trust in each other. There can be structural holes without brokerage, and there can also be brokerage without structural holes: brokerage behavior can, and often does, occur in dense networks.

Previous work on brokerage, particularly in the processual tradition, has also identified categories of brokers depending on the nature of their activities. Middleman, transfer, or conduit brokers facilitate economic transactions without necessarily altering the structure of a local network, like stockbrokers (Stovel and Shaw 2012, p. 146; Spiro, Acton, and Butts 2013; Obstfeld, Borgatti, and Davis 2014, p. 141). Catalyst, moderator, or matchmaking brokers focus on creating lasting ties, like headhunters and party hosts (Stovel and Shaw 2012, p. 146; Obstfeld, Borgatti, and Davis 2014; Spiro, Acton, and Butts 2013). Finally, *coordinators*, such as middle managers or disaster response teams, work to transform existing ties by reconfiguring local networks of interdependence (Spiro, Acton, and Butts 2013, pp. 131–132).

While definitions based on structural holes were very restrictive, Obstfeld and co-authors' processual definition is sweeping. For instance, they suggested that, under their definition, a manufacturing firm acts as a broker when it buys raw materials from an alter, transforms them into a product, and sells the finished product to another alter (Obstfeld, Borgatti, and Davis 2014, p. 145). Most triadic or polyadic relations, in this account, imply brokerage. Indeed, many descriptions of brokers in the literature are so broad as to invite the charge that a concept that explains everything explains nothing. The most varied social facts have been described as acts of brokerage: mediating conflict (Obstfeld, Borgatti, and Davis 2014), reselling stolen property (Steffensmeier 1986), advocating on behalf of someone, making sense of the world for someone, and helping connect epistemic communities (Stovel and Shaw 2012, p. 140), to name only a few.

C Shortcomings of Existing Frameworks

Work that relies chiefly on the structural holes idea generally makes clear that transferring knowledge and ideas is a key element of brokering and of the broker advantage. Yet the information under consideration is generally preexisting and ambient, not generated by brokering itself (Burt 2004). Moreover, the structural account leaves the actual work of brokering largely implicit. Structural position indicates places where brokerage is possible, but not whether anyone is doing the work of brokering—work for which structural holes are neither necessary nor sufficient.

Meanwhile, broad processual definitions blur the lines between vicarious and personal relational work. They include under the same umbrella cases where the intermediary deals with others on its own account, and cases where the intermediary works on behalf of others. As such, this perspective does not examine the informational byproduct that results from repeated vicarious work. Information is often simply listed among the resources that can be transferred through a broker, along with material or financial resources (see, e.g. Obstfeld, Borgatti, and Davis 2014, p. 141; Stovel and Shaw 2012, p. 141).

Neither perspective offers a cohesive theory of the role of information in brokerage, even though information shapes every stage of the brokering process. Before brokerage, the distribution of information shapes the opportunity or need for it: brokerage arises partly out of informational inequality, and the broker exploits what it knows that one or both sides do not. During brokerage, the transmission of information is part of the brokerage act itself, as the broker shares enough to make a match viable while withholding enough to preserve its advantage. After brokerage, the distribution of information has been altered, and the work has generated a byproduct the broker retains, which may shape the broker's opportunities. The circulation of information is at once a determinant of brokerage, a component of the work of brokering, and a consequence of brokerage.

This article reconceptualizes brokering as outsourced relational work and builds on this theoretical move to explain how brokerage sometimes weakens or disappears because a powerful broker captures resources or encloses data to become a principal.

III Outsourced Relational Work and the Broker Advantage

Social actors engage in *relational work* when they try to interpret and match social ties, economic transactions, and media of exchange, to create viable matches that will shape the outcome of their interaction (Zelizer 2012, p. 151, 2005; see also Bandelj 2020, p. 255). These matches and their shared meanings form distinct *relational packages*. For instance, in a marketplace, actors trading directly with one another draw on cultural knowledge to reach a shared understanding of their situation and the 'rules of the game,' and to agree on terms, including price (Block 2012, p. 137).

For the broker's clients, brokerage is *outsourced relational work*. For the broker, brokerage is *vicarious relational work*. In economic markets, this outsourced relational work is usually performed at scale by a *corporation*. This is more than a question of definitions: it shapes the broker's opportunities, its strategic advantage vis-à-vis its clients, and its trajectory.

A From Personal to *Outsourced and Vicarious* Relational Work

In brokered transactions, brokers take on the work of constructing a shared reality for limited purposes. The core of what brokers do is relational matching (see Zelizer 2012). Brokers are characterized by the relational work they do *on behalf of others*.

For the broker, this vicarious work requires another layer of relational work to negotiate brokerage relations with its clients. Brokerage corresponds with a distinct relational package. Not all intermediation is brokerage. In the relational package of economic brokerage, the broker performs a matching service for others, usually for a fee, commission, or retainer. Brokers bundle various services and amenities as part of that package: they take on the efforts of search and negotiation, they provide access to otherwise inaccessible counterparties, they share with their clients their expertise and the benefits of the private information they hold about quality, pricing, and availability, and they document and facilitate transactions, which often require logistical, bureaucratic, or regulatory work.

The middleman, catalyst, and coordination brokerage described in Section II are not exclusive categories of brokers, but rather, components of the work of brokering, which involves a bit of each in varying proportions. An important part of brokers' relational matching is to facilitate interaction (middleman brokerage), but this work also directly impacts interpersonal relations and local networks, often in an enduring way, by creating new and lasting ties (catalyst brokerage) or by reorganizing local networks (coordination brokerage).

Brokerage inherits the dual character of relational work, which can both foster and reduce informational asymmetry when constructing shared understandings while maintaining strategic opacities (Block 2012, p. 138). In performing relational work on behalf of others, the broker simultaneously clarifies and obscures: it transmits enough information to make a transaction legible and a match viable and conceals enough to justify its fee and preserve its advantage. The same opacity can do social as well as economic work. Rossman (2014) shows how brokerage functions as obfuscatory relational work that manages the taboos around disreputable exchange. Outsourcing relational work provides cover to parties in morally fraught matches. What the broker withholds is also the raw material of its later advantage: information that it withholds, accumulates, and, under the right conditions, eventually monetizes.

Vicarious work relates to entities or resources that are *not* under the broker's personal ownership and control, and the shared understanding of the parties is that the broker is *not a principal* in the brokered transaction (see, e.g. Stovel, Golub, and Milgrom 2011, p. 21326). Brokers generally have limited personal involvement in brokered interactions beyond their role as facilitators. The broker is a supporting actor, not a main character. Intermediaries who have full control over traded resources occupy a very different position in terms of risk, power, and vulnerability.

Another way to put it is that in economic markets, brokers are intermediaries that *do not assume inventory risk*. That is, if Bob helps Alice and Charlie conclude a sale, Bob is a broker. If Bob buys from Alice and eventually leases to Charlie, he is not. For instance, a real estate broker using her market knowledge to buy houses in up-and-coming neighborhoods to rent to families no longer acts as a broker. Instead, the relational work she performs is personal: matching herself to sellers and renters.

B From Individual to *Corporate* Relational Work

The definition above applies naturally to describe individual brokers working with individual clients, such as a real estate agent, an insurance broker representative, or a matchmaker. Much of the work of brokerage, however, occurs at the corporate, organizational, or institutional level, where brokers are firms, and clients may also be.

To understand what happens when relational work is outsourced to corporations, we must first discuss how corporations perform relational work in the first place, for themselves as organizational social actors. Relational work scholarship initially focused on the intimate sphere and interpersonal relationships (for a review, see Bandelj 2020). But relational work also takes place in the economic sphere and at the organizational level. The relational work tradition has acknowledged the organizational question without fully resolving it. Bandelj (2012) noted that relational work between representatives of organizations solidifies into macrolevel structures, while Zelizer (2012, pp. 156–157) catalogued instances of relational work by firms in the field of labor relations. Bandelj's (2020) review of "scaling up" relational work surveyed studies operating at the organizational level, but they mainly focused on what people do with and to each other within organizations, not on the corporate form itself as a vehicle for relational work.

Firms must conduct relational work to manage contingent, fleeting ties and longer-term relationships with workers, consumers, suppliers, lenders, investors, bureaucrats, and so on. The properties of the corporate form matter to this work and make it distinct. The firm is not simply a site where interpersonal relational work occurs; nor is it a singular, scaled-up actor that performs relational work as an individual does.

Firms are groups of people in designated roles, following norms and practices, supported by procedures, interfaces, and infrastructures, and doing the everyday work of managing the firm's relationship with its environment "at the coalface" (Gray and Silbey 2014; Huising and Silbey 2018). The mining metaphor directs attention to the frontline of the organization, where people enact its dealings with the outside world and translate organizational imperatives into routine practice. Relational work, like everything the corporation does in the world, is enacted through the people, procedures, infrastructure, and algorithms working at the coalface. Because of its collective and distributed nature, it is never visible in its entirety to any of the people involved.

Most firms are also legally organized as corporations. The corporation is a political entity with emergent capacities for coordination, information processing, and strategic action that exceed the sum of its parts (Ciepley 2013; Farrell and Newman 2023). There is a fundamental asymmetry between corporate actors and natural persons (Coleman 1982, 1990). The corporation aggregates information across thousands or millions of interactions, while each natural person sees only their own. The corporation can persist indefinitely, while individual relationships are transient. The corporation coordinates strategically across its full portfolio of relationships, while each counterparty acts in isolation. As a result, when a corporate actor interacts with natural persons, the corporate actor has structural and informational advantages.

These asymmetries are not accidental byproducts of size: they are legally constituted features of the corporate form. The corporation is one of the core modules of the legal code of capital (Pistor 2019). Corporate law endows the firm with durability that outlasts any individual relationship,

priority that ranks its claims above those of other parties, and universality that makes those claims enforceable against the world, so that it can become a legal technology for concentrating and protecting accumulated advantages and leveraging them for productive purposes. These are the conditions under which corporate relational work takes place: it is inherently asymmetric, because of the different scales and material and informational resources of corporate and natural persons.

C Outsourcing Relational Work to Corporations: The Corporate Brokers

When a client outsources relational work to a corporate broker, the corporate broker performs that work through people and practices at the coalface, each working in some small way to define relational packages, perform appropriate matches, and shape information flows. The corporate form reorganizes vicarious relational work, distributes it across roles, and embeds it in routines and procedures. To orchestrate this, corporate brokers develop an organizational apparatus comprising internal and client-facing roles, information architectures and databases, contractual templates, and interfaces.

Saying a brokerage firm does relational work on behalf of its clients means that in sales meetings, in contract negotiations, in the design of user interfaces, in the defaults embedded in terms of service, and so on, people relying on organizational procedures are working to define the features of its clients' relationships, what transactions are appropriate to them, and what media may govern the exchanges. As with its own relational work, the corporation has a capacity for coordination, information aggregation, and temporal persistence that makes the vicarious relational work of corporate brokerage qualitatively different from what any individual could accomplish alone.

The corporate broker's relation with its clients is structurally asymmetric. With human clients, corporate and natural persons bring fundamentally different legal, informational, and temporal architectures to the relationship. Even with corporate clients, however, the asymmetry remains: the broker coordinates vicarious relational work strategically and benefits from cross-market information, while the client encounters it piecemeal. The matching of relations, transactions, and media moves from a pure negotiation between principals with comparable standing, who learn from each transaction, toward an administered process in which the corporate broker sets the terms, explicitly or behind the scenes, and captures the information that each pairing generates.

The data infrastructure of the corporate broker includes data taxonomies, client categories, risk models, algorithmic sorting procedures, and so on. This infrastructure does not merely facilitate transactions but actively constitutes relational packages by determining what transactions are possible, and what categories they should fall into. Classification systems and information infrastructures, like those of the corporate broker, are not neutral descriptions of the world; they actively organize social relations (Bowker and Star 1999; Fourcade and Healy 2024). The corporate broker's information infrastructure, much like a corporate rating agency's credit-scoring system or a platform's matching algorithm, sorts counterparties into categories the broker defines and uses those categories to allocate opportunities according to the broker's objectives. The impact of the broker's information infrastructure is magnified because the corporate broker works at scale, while individuals cannot usually design categories that simultaneously structure millions of relationships.

D The Broker Advantage

Why do people and firms outsource their relational work to brokers? To have the opportunity to broker, a participant in a matching market must hold either a *structural* or an *informational* advantage. A structural advantage arises from network position and can be used to provide *access*: the broker bridges by bringing together parties that were not previously connected. An informational advantage supports *assessment*: the broker evaluates prospective matches better than its clients can. The broker's service is therefore valuable when it helps clients reach counterparties they could not otherwise find or better evaluate counterparties already available to them.

Assessment involves two components: (i) evaluating the individual quality of the goods or counterparties involved and (ii) evaluating their complementarity, that is, the quality of the specific pairing or relational package being considered. Individual quality and complementarity each contribute to the value that a match generates for its parties.

In some markets, for example on the New York Stock Exchange, complementarity does not matter much or at all. In markets with limited liquidity, no centralized trading venue, or nonfungible goods, however, like the labor market, the market for art, or over-the-counter financial markets, complementarity becomes very important.

Individual quality and complementarity correspond to two channels for the broker's informational advantage: *attributional*, about evaluating how parties' attributes translate into individual quality, and *relational*, about evaluating which counterparties best complement each other. Both are self-reinforcing, as the broker accumulates the knowledge required for assessment through the relational work it performs, and that learning makes it better at the work. The broker observes outcomes from many pairings across many principals, while each principal observes only its own. This gives the broker both a cross-market view and higher data volume.

The broker's information work can be informal and internal, as with a real estate broker who knows the local market, has an intuition for the right asking price, and holds social ties to likely buyers. It can also be formal and bureaucratized, as with a corporate mortgage broker that follows tables and formulas to determine which interest rate may produce successful matches between borrowers and lenders. The latter records and retains what the former holds in personal notes or experience.

Important models in the economics literature have focused on the attributional channel and characterized the broker's role primarily as quality certification (Li 1998) or expert screening (Bethune, Sultanum, and Trachter 2022): the broker identifies which goods or counterparties are high quality. In that view, the broker is an appraiser whose cross-market experience helps it assess the individual quality of counterparties more accurately than individual principals can. In contrast, the relational-work view of brokerage suggests that the broker's value lies also, and often primarily, in understanding complementarities between counterparties and shaping relational packages accordingly. The broker is a relational worker and a matchmaker whose advantage comes from the ability to make pairings and to know which pairings will likely succeed, an ability that improves with repeated matchmaking.

The model that follows illustrates the basis for the theory: a repeat-player broker observes outcomes across clients and uses the resulting information to organize subsequent matches. The model portrays how the broker's work, outsourcing rates, and network topology can evolve together.

IV How Brokers Accumulate Informational and Structural Advantage: A Formal Illustration

A Model and Methods

I use an agent-based model (ABM) to formalize the theory. The model is meant as an illustration of the theory, serving as a bridge from theory to testable propositions. Complete pseudocode and specifications appear in Appendices A and B. The public Git repository (`https://github.com/m-laprise/brokerage-abm`) contains the Julia code and scripts needed to reproduce the simulations, statistics, figures, and manuscript text.

Market and match output. Principals are the market participants seeking partners. Many principals and one broker occupy an undirected network. Each principal has a fixed vector of observable characteristics, which defines its type. At baseline, types are drawn around a smooth curve in an eight-dimensional space of observable characteristics (Supplementary Figure S1). For a given

pair, the true noise-free portion of the output that will be generated by their match (hereafter, the underlying match value) is fixed by the two principals' characteristics and the matching environment drawn at the start of each simulation run. This value excludes match noise, search costs, and broker fees. Underlying match value combines two components: individual qualities and complementarity (Appendix B §2). Each principal's individual quality is a function of its own characteristics and the mapping from characteristics to quality is fixed and shared across the market. The individual-quality component is the average of the two principals' individual quality. Complementarity depends on how their characteristics interact.

When underlying match value depends only on individual quality, all principals have the same ranking of shared candidates by underlying match value. With complementarity in the equation, these rankings can differ across principals (Supplementary Figure S2). Predicting individual quality corresponds to attributional assessment; predicting complementarity corresponds to relational assessment (see section III.D).

Before they are combined, the individual-quality and complementarity components are centered and scaled to have equal average within-market variances across the calibration markets. They receive weights $\sqrt{\rho}$ and $\sqrt{1-\rho}$, respectively. On this calibration scale, the individual-quality component accounts for a fraction ρ of the two weighted components' summed marginal variances, and complementarity accounts for $1-\rho$. At $\rho = 0$, underlying match value depends only on complementarity; at $\rho = 1$, it depends only on individual quality. The parameter δ controls the difficulty of learning complementarity by varying how sharply complementarity changes across an arbitrary boundary in type-pair space: it multiplies complementarity by $1+\delta$ on one side and $1-\delta$ on the other. Larger values make otherwise similar pairs on opposite sides of the boundary differ more in underlying match value. Changing ρ and δ changes the shape of the distribution of match values.

The normalization sets the average within-market variance of underlying match value to one in independently generated calibration markets, providing a common reference scale across simulations. The normalization coefficients remain fixed over time as turnover occurs and principals enter and exit, keeping the matching function stable. The range of underlying match values across pairs varies with ρ and δ. The range is wider in complementarity-dominated regimes. Increasing the difficulty widens it further by amplifying interactions for some of the pairs while suppressing them for others. This concentrates variation among the amplified pairs and leads to more extreme values even after normalization.

A different total net output to principals across such regimes cannot be cleanly attributed to a difference in matching performance. Consequently, when comparing regimes with different matching compositions or difficulties, I report differences in the share of principals' net output from brokered or self-search matches. I compare net output levels between service versions within each regime. Because δ affects only complementarity, it has no effect when $\rho = 1$. Describing variation in underlying match value across pairs requires more dimensions when complementarity contributes than when underlying match value depends only on individual quality, particularly when difficulty is high (Supplementary Figure S3).

When a pair matches, its realized match output equals its underlying match value plus an independent, mean-zero random shock. This shock represents match-specific variation that neither the principals nor the broker can anticipate.

Search, matching, and learning. Each period, principals seek pairwise matches either through self-search or through the broker (Appendix A §§5–7; Appendix B §§6–7). They choose one channel using satisfaction with the returns on their past matching requests, after search costs or broker fees. Self-search considers existing neighbors and a small random sample of other principals. The broker

considers principals in its standing roster (a persistent list of contacts), and those currently using its services.

Principals and the broker accumulate observations and learn in parallel. After every completed match, each principal records its partner's characteristics and the realized output, whether the match was arranged through self-search or through the broker. The broker also records both parties' characteristics and realized output from every match it mediates, pooling observations across clients. It does not observe matches arranged entirely through self-search.

Each principal uses its own observations to estimate the underlying value of pairing with a candidate, using that candidate's characteristics. The broker uses its pooled observations to estimate this value from both parties' characteristics. These estimates are the principals' and broker's predicted match values. In the main variant, each principal has its own neural network, and so does the broker. In another variant, these predictions use ridge regression.

Predicted match value determines how candidates are ranked. For previously matched neighbors, self-search uses the pair's average past realized output as its prediction. Candidates with equal scores are ordered uniformly at random. Principals make offers to the highest-ranked candidates with whom the predicted value of a match exceeds the reservation threshold. All offers enter a common market. A completed match creates a direct tie that persists until either principal exits. At the end of each period, every principal exits independently with probability η (the turnover rate) and is replaced by a new entrant.

Measurement. The outsourcing rate is the share of requested match positions routed through the broker. A brokered placement is classified as access when it creates a direct tie between previously unconnected principals and as assessment when it reuses an existing tie. The access fraction is the share of brokered placements classified as access. Net output per principal is total realized match output, counting each completed relationship once, minus all self-search costs and broker fees, divided by the number of principals. Self-search costs include costs incurred on unsuccessful searches. Appendix B §8 defines how output and costs are assigned to each channel. Broker betweenness centrality measures the share of shortest paths between principals that pass through the broker (Brandes 2001; Freeman 1977). Supplementary Figures S5–S6 report the corresponding structural comparisons using Burt's constraint and effective size.

Prediction quality is evaluated each period using randomly sampled potential partners. These evaluations do not update either model. Each predicted match value is compared with a pair's underlying value. Rank correlation is Spearman's correlation between the candidate ordering produced by predicted match values and the ordering produced by underlying match values. The ranking advantage is the broker's rank correlation minus the principals' rank correlation (Appendix B §8).

Simulation design and analysis. At the baseline, $N = 1{,}000$ principals interact for $T = 500$ periods with $\rho = 0.5$, $\delta = 0.5$, and $\eta = 0.02$ (Appendix B §9). The one-at-a-time sweeps and four two-parameter grids are described in the supplementary section "Simulation design and analysis" (Tables S1–S2). I refer to each unique model configuration as a regime. Together, the main sweeps contain 80 regimes. There are 20 random seeds per regime and 50 at the baseline (1630 runs for each learning model).

Before running the main simulations, I calibrated the neural networks' learning rates and numbers of training updates separately for principals and the broker. I considered ranking performance on randomly sampled candidates, stability over time and across random seeds, and computational time.

To show that the findings do not depend on neural-network learning, I repeat the complete design with ridge regression. In the ridge specification, principals use candidate characteristics, while the broker uses both parties' characteristics and interactions between them. I calibrated the ridge penalties at the baseline, considering ranking performance on randomly sampled candidates, stability over time

and across random seeds, and prediction error. Three additional ridge experiments, conducted at the baseline and across the $\rho \times \delta$ grid, restrict the broker by capping its fitting sample at the median sample size among principals, retaining only one party's characteristics from each match, or omitting interactions between the two parties' characteristics.

To examine the value and structural consequences of assessment and access, I compare three versions of the broker's service, all using neural-network learning. Full service combines the broker's assessments with access to its contacts and current clients. Assessment-only uses the broker's assessments to rank candidates available through ordinary self-search. Access-only ranks the broker's broader candidate set using principals' own assessments. In each version, the broker still organizes matches, charges the same fee, and observes and learns from the matches it arranges. The service remains fixed throughout each simulation. Changing the service changes matches, outsourcing, network formation, and subsequent learning. The comparisons capture these combined effects.

Ensemble means are averages across random seeds. The late window covers periods 481–500; the early window covers periods 51–70. Betweenness, constraint, and effective size are computed every 20 periods; their early and late summaries use network snapshots at periods 60 and 500, respectively. Other measures are averaged within each window. Unless otherwise noted in a figure caption, time-series figures begin at $t = 30$ to omit the initialization transient.

I report pointwise 95% Student-t Monte Carlo confidence intervals across independent runs to quantify uncertainty in the estimated means. For comparisons between model versions or regimes, I first calculate outcome differences between runs using the same random seed, then construct intervals for the mean difference across seeds.

Across the main simulations and additional experiments, I assessed how sensitive the reported early and late estimates were to chance variation associated with the particular random seeds used to generate the simulation runs. This assessment covered mean outcomes, paired differences between conditions, and ratios of ensemble output means. I compared estimates based on the first 10 versus all 20 seeds outside the baseline and the first 20 versus all 50 seeds at the baseline.

In the results sections that follow, I describe four salient and sometimes counterintuitive dynamics that emerge from this simple set-up: (i) the broker primarily provides assessment, not access; (ii) access brokerage can raise principals' net output while eroding broker structural advantage; meanwhile, assessment brokerage can sustain brokerage even when no access is provided; (iii) the broker's informational advantage comes from data volume and relational information; and finally, (iv) a broker can be highly central while doing little bridging.

B The Broker Primarily Provides Assessment, Not Access

Most brokered placements involve counterparties that principals could already reach through ordinary self-search. In all 80 regimes, the late-mean share of brokered placements reusing an existing tie exceeds 80%. Yet principals route a majority of their matching requests through the broker in 78 regimes (late means; Figure 1, Panel C). Extensive use of brokerage therefore coexists with relatively little provision of new access. For most placements, the broker assesses and arranges a match between already connected principals.

This assessment role becomes more pronounced over time. At baseline, the outsourcing rate rises from an early mean of 78% to a late mean of 97%, while the access fraction falls from 20% to 11% (Figure 1, Panel A). The early-to-late decline in the access fraction occurs in every regime. The 95% Monte Carlo interval for the decrease excludes zero in each regime (Panel B). Principals thus continue outsourcing as the broker's work becomes increasingly concentrated within existing relationships.

Assessment guides the broker's selection of counterparties: its predicted match values determine how candidates are ranked and which offers are made first. The ranking diagnostic evaluates this

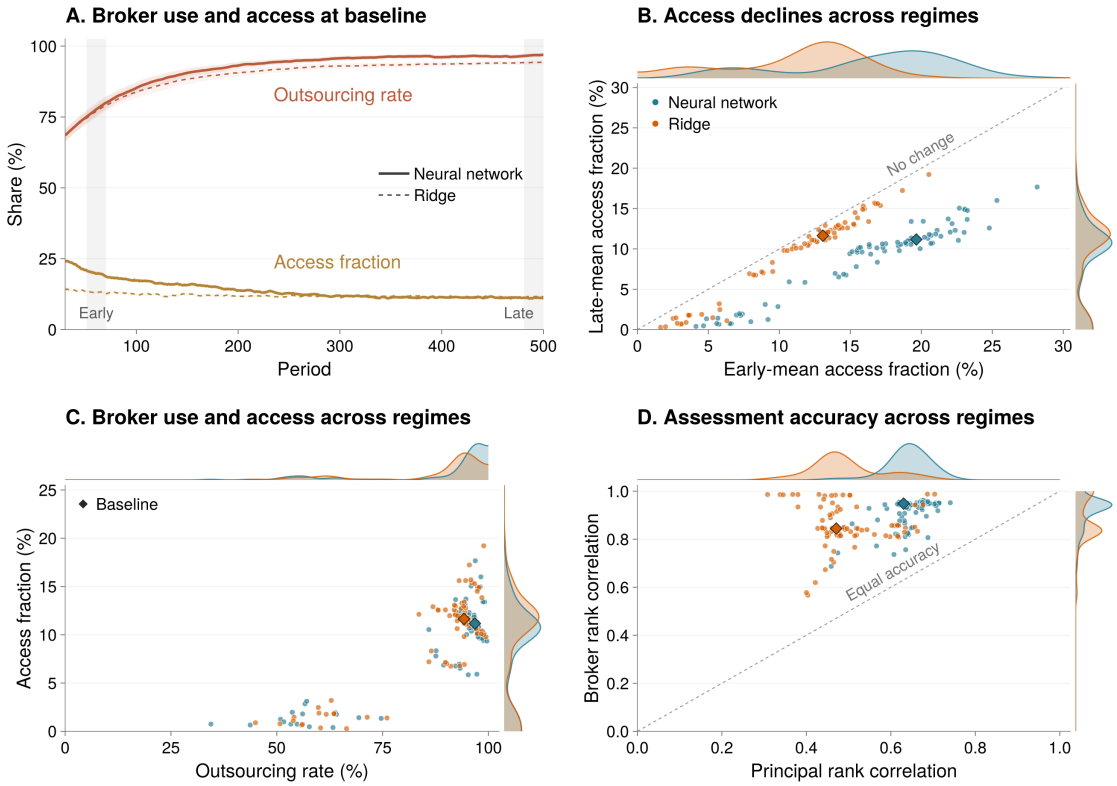


Figure 1: Broker use, access, and assessment accuracy. A: ensemble means after a 5-observation rolling mean within each seed, with pointwise 95% Monte Carlo intervals. B–D: ensemble means for 80 regimes; C–D use late means. Marginal curves show smoothed distributions of regime means, with equal weight per regime and common smoothing across learners.

component of the service by comparing the broker's and principals' predicted rankings against true rankings by underlying match value on the same randomly sampled candidates. At baseline, late-mean rank correlation is 0.95 for the broker and 0.63 for principals, with a 95% Monte Carlo interval of [0.31, 0.33] for the ranking advantage. That advantage is positive in every regime, with the 95% Monte Carlo interval excluding zero in each regime (Figure 1, Panel D).

The predominance of assessment compared to access also persists when the broker and the principals use ridge regression to make their predictions instead of neural-network learning. In the ridge variant, late-mean outsourcing exceeds one-half in 79 of 80 regimes, and the late-mean share of brokered placements reusing existing ties exceeds 80% in every regime (Figure 1, Panel C). Neural-network learning raises principals' late-mean ranking accuracy in all 80 regimes and narrows the broker's ranking advantage in 64 (Panel D), yet extensive outsourcing and the predominance of assessment persist.

Together, these findings identify assessment rather than new access as the broker's predominant service. Principals outsource the evaluation and arrangement of matches even when the counterparties involved are already reachable.

C The Value and Structural Consequences of Access and Assessment

The broker ranks candidates more accurately than principals, but ranking accuracy alone does not establish how much its assessments contribute to principals' net output. The assessment and access experiment examines these contributions by comparing full service with assessment-only and access-only service across 11 regimes varying turnover and matching composition. Each simulation uses one version of the broker's service throughout. Changing that service affects which principals match, how much demand they route through the broker, which ties form among principals and with the broker, and what principals and the broker subsequently learn.

C.1 The Broker Can Benefit Principals by Providing Access While Eroding Its Structural Advantage

A broker can increase principals' net output by providing access to counterparties beyond those available through ordinary self-search, even when most of its placements reuse existing ties. At baseline, principals' late-mean net output is 1.02 higher per principal under full service than under assessment-only service, with a 95% Monte Carlo interval of [0.96, 1.08] (Figure 2, Panel A). Principals therefore benefit when the broker provides broader access alongside its assessments, even though only a minority of its placements connect previously unconnected principals.

This benefit depends on how frequently principals need new relationships. When 1% or 3% of participants leave and are replaced each period, principals obtain higher net output under full service than under assessment-only service across all matching compositions. Without turnover, principals obtain less net output under full service than under assessment-only service (Supplementary Figure S4, Panel B). Turnover continually removes principals and their relationships, making the broker's broader contacts useful for finding new counterparties. In stable markets, accumulated relationships and ordinary self-search already provide a viable candidate pool, so the broker does not necessarily improve principals' net output by reaching additional candidates.

The relative contributions of assessment and access also depend on principals' need for new relationships. Under pure complementarity and no turnover, principals' late-mean net output is 0.26 higher per principal under assessment-only than under access-only service, with a 95% Monte Carlo interval of [0.22, 0.30]. When 3% of participants leave and are replaced each period, principals' late-mean net output is 0.22 higher per principal under access-only than under assessment-only service, with a 95% Monte Carlo interval of [0.13, 0.32] (Supplementary Figure S4, Panels A–B).

Comparing full service with assessment-only service also reveals a structural cost for the broker. At baseline, principals have more network ties on average under full service than under assessment-only service: their late-mean degree is 17.73 rather than 15.52. Degree counts each principal's ties to other principals and its tie to the broker when present. Meanwhile, the broker has lower betweenness centrality at period 500, 0.79 rather than 0.85 (Figure 2, Panel B). Both directions hold in all 11 regimes. The 95% Monte Carlo intervals for both differences exclude zero in every regime.

Providing assessment has the opposite effect on the broker's betweenness centrality. At baseline matching composition ($\rho = 0.5$), the broker has higher betweenness centrality at period 500 under full service than under access-only service at every turnover rate. The 95% Monte Carlo interval for this difference excludes zero at every rate (Panel B).

When the broker arranges a match between previously unconnected principals, they acquire a direct tie. By helping principals form these relationships, the broker erodes the betweenness centrality it would otherwise accumulate. This is a self-liquidating force, not an inevitable absolute decline. At baseline, the broker's betweenness centrality rises even under access-only service, because principals' continued outsourcing still connects them to the broker (Figure 2, Panel D).

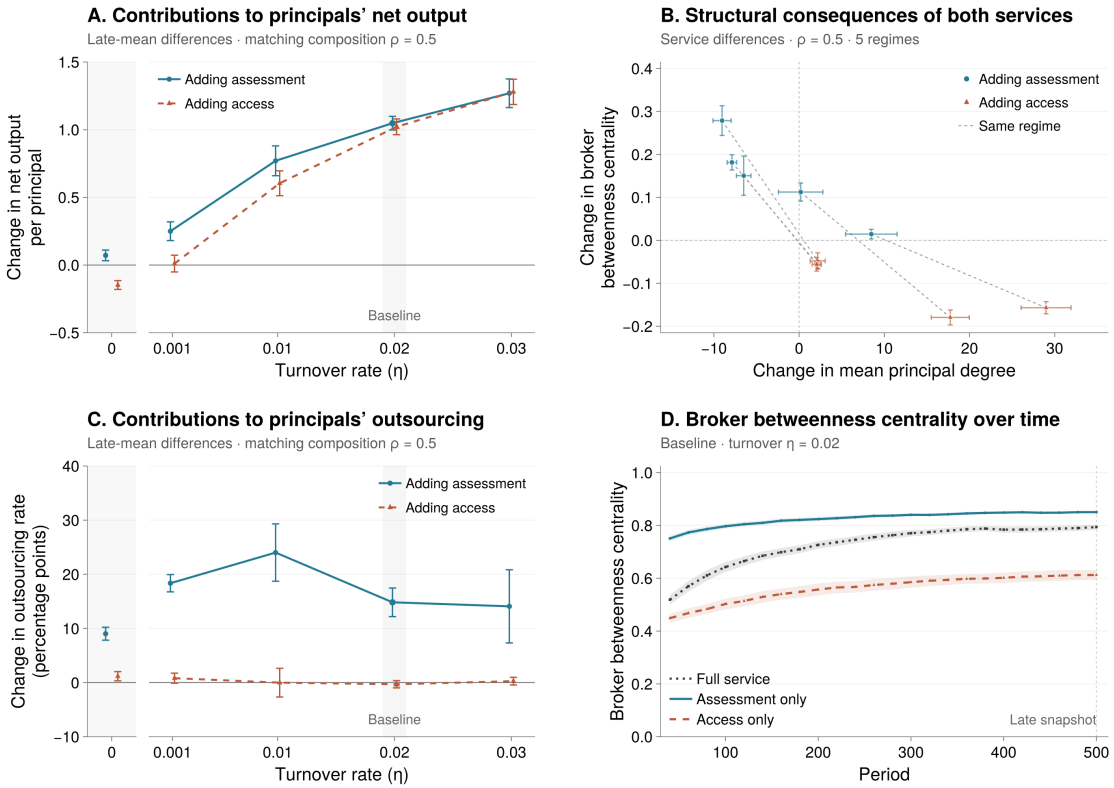


Figure 2: Brokerage with access, assessment, or both. Parameters other than turnover remain at baseline. A–C show differences between services: adding assessment is full service minus access-only; adding access is full service minus assessment-only. Betweenness in B uses period 500; other measures in A–C use late-window averages. Dashed lines in B connect contrasts within each regime; principal degree includes the broker tie when present. Zero turnover is plotted separately in A and C. D shows unsmoothed ensemble means. Bars and ribbons show pointwise 95% Monte Carlo intervals, paired by seed in A–C.

C.2 The Broker Can Sustain Demand Through Assessment Without Providing Additional Access

The broker's assessments contribute to principals' net output alongside its broader contacts. At baseline, principals' late-mean net output is 1.05 higher per principal under full service than under access-only service, with a 95% Monte Carlo interval of [1.00, 1.10], compared with a gain of 1.02 over assessment-only service (Figure 2, Panel A).

Principals continue to request brokerage even when the broker evaluates only candidates available through ordinary self-search. At baseline, late-mean outsourcing is 97% under assessment-only service, compared with 97% under full service and 82% under access-only service. Principals outsource more when the broker uses its own assessments rather than theirs in every regime. The 95% Monte Carlo interval for this difference excludes zero in each regime. When the broker adds access to assessment-only service, principals make smaller changes in the share of requests they outsource, increasing it in some regimes and decreasing it in others (Figure 2, Panel C).

These choices depend on principals' satisfaction with brokerage relative to self-search, based on the returns on their past matching requests after costs. Principals can therefore continue using the broker because their satisfaction with its service is high, because their satisfaction with self-search is low, or

because both are true. Continued outsourcing establishes the broker's relative attractiveness, while the net-output comparisons establish the contribution of its assessments to principals' returns.

The assessment-only result also connects the ABM to data enclosure. The broker continues to create value for principals when it only assesses candidates they could reach through ordinary self-search. Its knowledge is therefore valuable independently of broader access. The experiment does not model data enclosure itself, because the broker still mediates matches and learns from them, but it establishes its prerequisite: assessment can become a distinct service that could be unbundled from intermediation and sold as predictions or analytics.

D The Broker's Informational Advantage Comes from Data Volume and Relational Information

The broker learns from the matches it arranges across principals, whereas each principal learns only from its own matches. This difference can support an assessment advantage in two ways: the broker has more observations, and it can learn how different parties' characteristics combine to determine the value of a match. Three experiments distinguish these sources by reducing either the broker's training sample or the information it uses about each pairing.

All three experiments use ridge regression for principals and the broker. The reference broker retains data about both parties to each brokered match and learns how their characteristics interact. Each restriction is compared with this reference across 31 regimes varying matching composition and difficulty.

Reducing the broker's training sample sharply narrows its advantage. The first restriction gives it as many observations as a typical principal, sampled from its records of brokered matches, with data about both parties retained. At baseline, its late-mean rank correlation falls from 0.84 in the reference version to 0.76, with a 95% Monte Carlo interval of [0.08, 0.10] for the decrease (Figure 3, Panel A). Its ranking advantage, the broker-minus-principal difference in rank correlation, falls from 0.37 to 0.04, with a 95% Monte Carlo interval of [0.32, 0.35] for the decrease. This larger change also reflects more accurate principal rankings: their late-mean rank correlation rises from 0.47 to 0.72.

Restricting the broker's learning throughout the simulation changes the matches it arranges and thus the observations from which principals learn. The broker's rank correlation and its ranking advantage are lower than in the reference version in all 31 regimes. For each measure, the 95% Monte Carlo interval for the decrease excludes zero in every regime. A smaller ranking advantage persists in most regimes. At baseline, the late-mean share of principals' net output from brokered matches falls from 96% in the reference version to 81%, while total net output is 97% of reference output (Panel B). Higher net output from self-search partially offsets lower net output from brokered matches.

Data volume does not explain the advantage by itself. Each principal's observations hold one party fixed: itself. The second broker restriction retains data about only one party to each match, alongside its realized output, while continuing to combine observations across principals. At baseline, the broker's late-mean rank correlation falls from 0.84 to 0.44, and its ranking advantage reverses from 0.37 to -0.25 (Panel A). The 95% Monte Carlo interval for this broker-minus-principal difference is [-0.30, -0.20]. Both measures are lower than in the reference version in all 31 regimes. For each measure, the 95% Monte Carlo interval for the decrease excludes zero in every regime. In 21 regimes, the Monte Carlo interval for its ranking advantage lies entirely below zero. At baseline, the late-mean share of principals' net output from brokered matches falls from 96% in the reference version to 55%, and total net output is 90% of reference output (Panel B).

Retaining data about both parties also differs from learning how they combine. The third restriction omits the interaction term from the broker's predictions: it uses data about both parties, but one party's contribution cannot depend on the other's characteristics. At baseline, the broker's late-mean

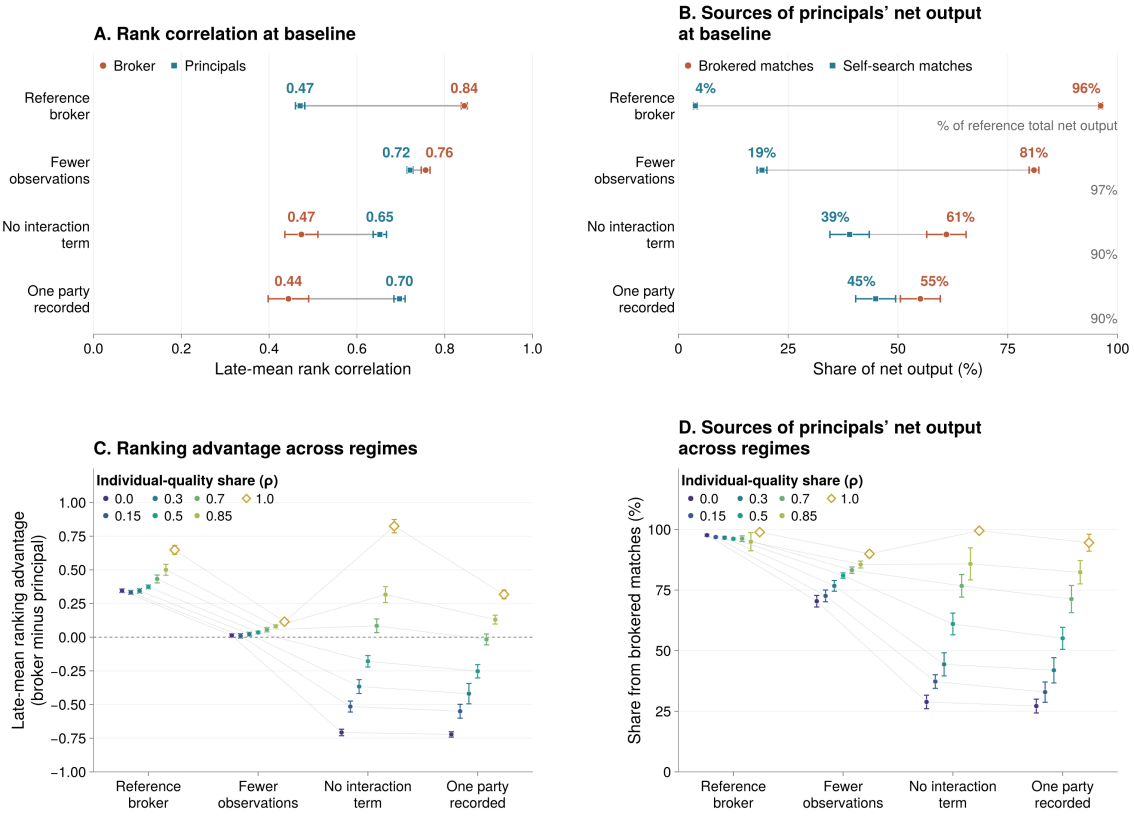


Figure 3: Sources of the broker's advantage. Ensemble late means from the ridge experiments. Rank correlations use the same randomly sampled candidates for principals and the broker. In C–D, parameters other than ρ remain at baseline; gray lines connect the same regime across versions. Whiskers show pointwise 95% Monte Carlo intervals. C uses within-seed broker-minus-principal differences. B and D average seed-level ratios of late-mean channel net output to late-mean total net output. B's right-hand percentages compare ensemble-mean total net output with the reference version.

rank correlation falls from 0.84 to 0.47 and its ranking advantage from 0.37 to -0.18 (Panel A). The 95% Monte Carlo interval for the 0.55 decrease in ranking advantage is [0.51, 0.60]. At baseline, the late-mean share of principals' net output from brokered matches falls from 96% in the reference version to 61%, and total net output is 90% of reference output (Panel B).

The broker's rank correlation is lower than in the reference version in all 30 regimes involving complementarity. The 95% Monte Carlo interval for the decrease excludes zero in every regime. Its ranking advantage also narrows in all 30 regimes. The 95% Monte Carlo interval for this decrease excludes zero in 29. When underlying match value depends only on individual quality, the restriction instead produces a higher broker rank correlation and a larger ranking advantage. Here, underlying match value depends on the parties' separate contributions, rather than how their characteristics interact. Omitting the interaction term matches this simpler relationship and avoids estimating interactions that do not contribute to underlying match value.

These effects illustrate the importance of relational assessment. Removing data about one party or the interaction term reduces the broker's ranking advantage most under pure complementarity (Panel C; Supplementary Figure S7, Panels A–E). At each difficulty level, these restrictions also shift a larger share of principals' net output from brokered matches toward self-search as complementarity

contributes more to underlying match value (Panel D; Supplementary Figure S7, Panels F–J). Learning how particular parties fit together, beyond assessing their individual quality, improves the broker's rankings and increases the share of principals' net output that comes from brokered matches.

Repeated vicarious relational work thus supplies both a larger sample and knowledge of which pairings succeed. Retaining data about both parties and learning how their characteristics combine make these observations useful for relational assessment.

E A Broker Can Be Highly Central While Doing Little Bridging

The broker can become more central even as a smaller share of its placements connects previously unconnected principals. At baseline in the main simulations, broker betweenness centrality rises from 0.57 at period 60 to 0.79 at period 500, while the access fraction falls from 20% to 11%. A larger share of the shortest paths between principals therefore passes through the broker, even as its work becomes increasingly assessment-based. Such a central position is usually associated with connecting otherwise disconnected parties, yet a growing share of the broker's work takes place within relationships that already exist.

The broker's betweenness centrality depends on two kinds of ties: those connecting principals to the broker and those connecting principals to one another. Continued outsourcing connects principals to the broker. When the broker arranges matches within existing relationships, it sustains these connections without creating additional direct ties among principals. Providing access, by contrast, creates direct ties that offer alternative shortest paths bypassing the broker. These opposing effects appear in the assessment and access experiment: providing access lowers broker betweenness centrality, whereas providing assessment raises it (Figure 2, Panel B).

Although brokerage is predominantly assessment-based across matching compositions, the broker's work becomes even more concentrated on assessment and its position in the network becomes more central as underlying match value shifts from depending mainly on individual quality to depending entirely on complementarity. At baseline turnover and difficulty, moving from $\rho = 0.85$ to $\rho = 0$ raises the late-mean share of brokered placements within existing relationships from 86% to 90% and broker betweenness centrality from 0.52 to 0.86 (Figure 4, Panel A). Both differences occur at all 5 turnover rates. The 95% Monte Carlo intervals for both differences exclude zero at every rate.

Extensive outsourcing and predominantly assessment-based brokerage do not by themselves ensure high broker betweenness centrality. The distribution of ties among principals also matters. When underlying match value depends only on individual quality ($\rho = 1$), with other parameters at baseline, the late-mean share of brokered placements within existing relationships is 89% and outsourcing remains high at 97%, but broker betweenness centrality is only 0.15. The same counterparties are attractive to many principals, allowing relationships to concentrate around them. The late mean of the maximum principal degree is 985.19, compared with 136.36 when underlying match value depends entirely on complementarity. Mean principal degree differs much less, at 19.36 and 15.77, respectively (Figure 4, Panel B). A modest average degree can therefore conceal highly connected principals that provide alternative shortest paths that bypass the broker.

The persistence of principals' relationships also matters. Turnover continually removes principals and their ties, limiting the accumulation of paths that bypass the broker. At baseline matching composition and difficulty, replacing 3% of principals each period rather than none lowers late-mean principal degree from 77.35 to 16.33 and raises broker betweenness centrality from 0.12 to 0.82 (Figure 4, Panel C). The access fraction also rises, from 1% to 15% (Panel A). A larger access fraction therefore does not necessarily imply lower broker betweenness centrality: newly formed ties can be offset by the loss of existing relationships.

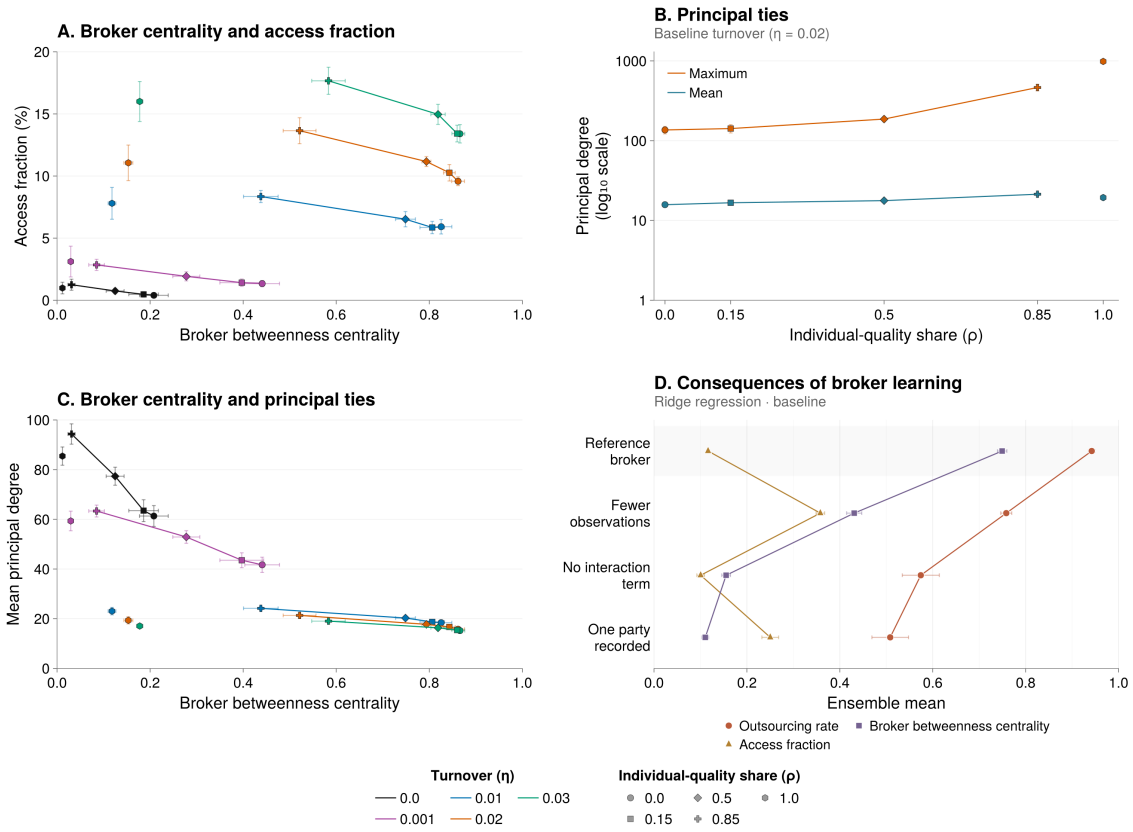


Figure 4: Bridging position and bridging behavior. Points show ensemble means, using betweenness at period 500 and late-window averages for other measures; whiskers show pointwise 95% Monte Carlo intervals. A–C use neural-network learning; parameters not varied in each panel remain at baseline. Principal degree includes the broker tie when present; maximum degree is calculated within each period before averaging. Lines connect matching compositions at fixed turnover in A and C and serve as visual guides across learning restrictions in D.

The data and learning capabilities behind the broker's assessment advantage also help sustain its bridging position. At baseline in the ridge experiment, omitting the interaction term reduces late-mean outsourcing from 94% to 57% and broker betweenness centrality from 0.75 to 0.16 (Figure 4, Panel D). The late-mean access fraction remains low, at 10% compared with 12% for the reference broker. In both versions, most brokered placements reuse existing relationships, but the broker has much lower betweenness centrality when principals use its service less. Learning how parties fit together thus helps sustain principals' use of the broker and the connections that make it central.

To assess how the structural findings depend on the measure used, I repeat the comparisons using Burt's constraint and effective size. Supplementary Figure S5 covers matching composition and turnover, and Supplementary Figure S6 covers service provision and learning. When underlying match value depends only on individual quality and turnover is 3%, providing access increases effective size, despite reducing betweenness centrality (Panel B).

Repeated vicarious relational work generates knowledge that can sustain principals' use of the broker. Sustained use converts the value of assessment into structural centrality, while the concentration

and persistence of principals' own relationships shape how much centrality the broker attains. High broker betweenness centrality can therefore coexist with little bridging.

F Propositions

The simulation results and theoretical argument motivate the following falsifiable propositions for future empirical research:

P1. ***When complementarity matters, brokers are valuable even when clients can find counterparties themselves***. Brokers help clients judge which counterparties would make good matches. These assessments become more valuable in markets where match outcomes depend more on how well the two parties fit together.

P2. ***Relationship disruption increases the value of access brokerage***. Clients gain more from brokers' ability to find new counterparties when market participants frequently leave and are replaced than when they can rely on stable relationships.

P3. ***When the broker records and accumulates data about its matching work, brokerage widens informational asymmetry***. Repeated brokerage increases the broker's assessment advantage over its clients, even though those clients also learn from the matches it arranges.

P4. ***Assessment brokerage can produce high broker centrality with little bridging behavior***. Sustained outsourcing connects principals to the broker. The centrality this produces depends on the concentration and persistence of ties among principals. Brokers whose assessments remain valuable relative to clients' independent alternatives can become highly central even when most of their matches involve counterparties already connected to one another.

P5. ***Assessment enables the broker to become a principal***. Corporate brokers whose assessments create value independently of privileged access are more likely to use that capability on their own behalf, either to acquire and sell resources they previously intermediated (resource capture) or to sell predictions or analytics directly (data enclosure).

V Transient Brokerage and Its Conditions of Possibility

The model formalizes how brokers accumulate and sustain informational and structural advantages, but it stops before the transition to principals.

I now return to the theoretical argument to explain how a corporate broker with the necessary infrastructure may convert its accumulated assessment capability into ownership or control. The broker can sell that capability directly through predictions or analytics (data enclosure), or apply it on its own behalf to acquire resources and profit from them (resource capture).

Outsourced relational work performed at scale by corporate brokers creates the conditions under which this conversion can occur. The broker dismantles the relational package previously negotiated with its clients and replaces it with a new configuration organized around the broker's ownership of the resources it used to intermediate (*resource capture*), or the monetization of the information generated through prior matching activity (*data enclosure*).

These configurations are two qualitatively different forms of capture, which can be pursued in parallel and along with standard brokering. In *resource capture*, the broker takes inventory risk and starts acting as a principal in the market it used to intermediate. It strategically acquires resources, and depending on the market in which it operates, it can resell them, lease them out, license them, etc. Counterparties interact only with the broker, without creating direct ties with one another. As the broker expands its principal activity and shrinks its matching services, former clients become

counterparties or competitors. In *data enclosure*, the broker monetizes information directly by selling predictions, analytics, or other information services, often as a subscription.

The assessment-only experiment provides a formal precursor to this transition. In that experiment, the broker provides no access beyond ordinary self-search, yet its assessments remain valuable to principals and sustain outsourcing. Data enclosure takes this separation one step further: the broker monetizes its accumulated assessment capability without necessarily continuing to mediate the transactions it evaluates.

What makes capture possible, I suggest, is primarily the broker's informational advantage, not its structural position. Structural and informational advantages are decoupled, and capture may occur even if the broker's centrality is declining. This is because constructing viable relational packages generates an informational byproduct that the broker can leverage. Two features of the broker's informational landscape facilitate capture: cumulative knowledge of complementarities coming from the *outsourced* nature of its relational work, and information infrastructures arising from its *corporate* nature. Other actors cannot easily replicate either advantage.

(i) The role of complementarity information. The broker's vicarious work generates knowledge of how different parties pair together, what kinds of matches succeed across the market, and what relational packages support different transactions. For regular market actors, this complementarity information is hard to replicate. Unlike attributional information about the individual quality of counterparties, which any actor with sufficient market exposure can in principle acquire, complementarity information is generated through the repeated observation of various pairings. The broker holds it because it does the matching for a variety of clients; clients, who experience only their own matches, do not—unless they purchase or otherwise acquire it. Complementarity information supports resource capture, because it allows the broker to identify which resources or counterparties are most likely to generate profitable matches, so that it can capture them strategically and offload them gainfully. Complementarity information also supports data enclosure because it can be packaged into prediction or analytics products and services.

(ii) The role of information infrastructures. The corporate broker's information infrastructure explains *how* its informational advantage can be preserved and converted. The taxonomies, classification systems, contractual templates, and algorithmic sorting procedures that the broker develops to perform vicarious work at scale and in a distributed manner, through the everyday work of its employees and representatives, are also the infrastructures through which capture can be realized. They can be repurposed to route resources to the broker itself, to put these resources back in circulation profitably, or to organize data into a marketable product. Moreover, the corporate form gives the broker the legal privileges required to build, own, and protect these infrastructures over time (Coleman 1982; Pistor 2019).

These features, and transient brokerage itself, can be found across markets. I illustrate each configuration with an example.

Dealers in collectible markets. Collectors of art, fine wine, rare books, or similar specialty goods may seek trades through broker-dealers who know the market. Each collector has distinct tastes and holdings; match quality depends on multidimensional complementarity between what one party has and what another wants. Dealers accumulate knowledge of collector preferences across transactions, and they may decide to leverage it and start holding inventory, for instance, by launching and operating a gallery.

Interdealer brokerage in over-the-counter (OTC) financial markets. Interdealer brokers (IDBs) are specialized intermediaries in OTC financial markets (e.g., bond markets, foreign exchange, commodities). IDBs help institutions like banks and dealers conclude large, complicated, or anonymous transactions in the absence of a centralized trading place. They solve a hard matching problem:

the right counterparty for a trade depends on inventory positions and risk appetites that parties wish to keep secret. IDBs must know who wants what, negotiate prices across hidden order interest, preserve anonymity until execution, and manage long-term client relationships to remain in the order flow. The complementarity information they accumulate, about who will absorb what positions at what price under what conditions, is substantial. Resource capture, however, faces regulatory and reputational hurdles. Instead, IDBs have monetized accumulated information through data divisions that package historical OTC pricing and other data products and sell them to the same dealers whose trades generated the data and to a wider set of buy-side firms and regulators (see, e.g. Parameta Solutions 2026; TP ICAP 2026).

In summary, three elements enable capture or enclosure: a matching problem that makes complementarity information valuable, an informational advantage accumulated through repeated vicarious relational work, and an institutional architecture that allows that information to be aggregated, organized, and protected. Brokerage becomes transient when matching on behalf of others becomes secondary or ceases entirely.

VI Discussion

A Structural Advantage as a Product of Relational Work

Within the agent-based model, the broker's centrality is a product of its relational work. Valuable assessments keep brokerage attractive relative to self-search and help sustain repeated outsourcing that, in turn, connects principals to the broker. The broker is more central when many principals outsource to it repeatedly. Its centrality rises and falls with outsourcing and satisfaction, but it also depends on the concentration and persistence of ties among principals.

The simulations show that the broker's relational work endogenously produces its structural advantage. This process generates two patterns that existing theory does not readily predict. The first is that the broker tends to be most central exactly where it bridges least in practice. Across variation in matching composition at a fixed turnover rate, centrality is negatively associated with the access fraction (Figure 4, Panel A): in the complementarity-dominated markets where the broker is most prominent, almost all its matches re-pair principals already tied to one another. A strong bridging position coincides with weak bridging behavior. Occupying a strategic position and using it for one's work are different things that theory should not conflate.

The second pattern concerns the sustainability of brokerage. A long-standing expectation is that brokerage tends to undermine its own structural basis (Burt 1992, 2002; Stovel, Golub, and Milgrom 2011). Each successful introduction creates a direct tie that can reduce future dependence on the broker. Access therefore creates a self-liquidating force, not an inevitable decline in broker centrality.

The experiment makes this distinction clear. At baseline turnover, the broker has lower betweenness centrality under full service than under assessment-only service, yet all three broker models gain centrality over the observed period (Figure 2, Panels B and D). Providing access can thus lower centrality relative to assessment-only without causing centrality to decline over time. Turnover removes ties and renews opportunities for brokerage, while valuable assessments can sustain outsourcing. A broker can therefore become more central even while its introductions weaken one source of its structural advantage.

The results also suggest a mechanism for the decoupling of structural and informational advantage posited in Section V. The features of the matching problem shape both advantages. As complementarity contributes more to underlying match value, retaining information about both parties and their interaction becomes more important to the broker's ranking advantage. At fixed turnover and difficulty, shifting from predominantly individual quality to pure complementarity also corresponds

to higher broker betweenness centrality and to brokerage that is more concentrated on assessment (Figure 4, Panel A).

Yet, a broker can be highly central despite a modest ranking advantage or hold a decisive ranking advantage from an unremarkable position. Extensive outsourcing does not by itself ensure high centrality. When underlying match value depends only on individual quality, outsourcing remains high, but relationships concentrate around attractive principals, creating paths that bypass the broker and limiting its betweenness centrality (Figure 4, Panel B). The broker's ranking advantage can sustain demand for its services, but the relationships among principals shape the structural prominence that demand produces, and those relationships in turn depend on the features of the matching problem. Betweenness centrality is best understood not as a static measure of opportunity but as a product of the relational work the broker performs. Informational advantage and structural prominence need not move together.

B Scope Conditions and Generalizability

The concept of transient brokerage applies most directly to matching markets in which (i) the value of a match depends not only on the individual quality of each party but also on their complementarity and (ii) a corporate broker operates as a repeat player accumulating information across transactions. The further a case departs from these conditions, the weaker the predictions of the theory. When the relational dimension is weak, the broker's advantage rests primarily on data volume about multiple counterparties, making its informational position less privileged. When the broker is a natural person, they lack the temporal persistence, infrastructural capacity, and legal architecture that the corporate broker relies on. Conversely, the transition described by the theory is most plausible when the broker combines broad knowledge of past matches with the organizational and legal capacity to retain, organize, and control data.

The dynamics of transient brokerage also depend on the nature of the brokered resource and the institutional environment. In a goods market where items are bulky and physical delivery is required, the costs and logistics of capture differ substantially from those in a market for services or a market where goods are virtual or ownership passes without physical possession. In some markets, regulation may slow or prevent capture. Market structure matters as well. The model considered in this article features a single broker. With multiple brokers competing for the same clients or matches, the cross-market data pool is fragmented, and each broker may accumulate a smaller informational advantage, unless one or a few brokers dominate the market. A systematic treatment of broker competition is deferred to future work.

Transient brokerage is relevant to a particular configuration of brokerage, in which the matching problem, corporate form, and information accumulation give rise to a distinctive trajectory. The sociological literature has used brokerage to describe a wide range of phenomena, from immigrant children translating for their parents to marriage matchmakers and political brokers. The relational-work view of brokerage developed in this article can be applied to what many of these so-called brokers do. Without the repeat-player structure of corporate brokerage, the legal and infrastructural architecture of the firm, and an economic matching problem complex enough to sustain an informational advantage, however, the pathway to capture is not the same.

These scope conditions point to candidate domains in which to test the theoretical propositions. Real estate and various types of financial intermediation, including interdealer brokerage, combine complex matching, corporate repeat-player brokers, and meaningful complementarity information. Import-export management and data markets also share many of these features.

C The Political Economy of Corporate Intermediation

The corporate broker is a vehicle for the accumulation of information generated by the interactions between others, and the principals whose matching activity produced the information do not participate in the profits. The asymmetries that make capture possible are not just a byproduct of a broker's size or expertise. They are legally constituted. Corporate brokers assemble cross-market data and build classification systems and information infrastructures under the legal protections of the corporate form, which allows vicarious relational work to solidify into a durable informational moat. Whether a broker can convert its informational position into resource ownership or data provision depends on the institutional environment as much as on network position.

When the broker acts as a principal, it changes who gets connected to whom. The principals observe fewer matches than they otherwise would, and many matches in the market teach them nothing at all. The informational asymmetry that makes capture possible is widened by capture itself: the broker takes control not only of the resource but of the data its placement generates. Transient brokerage shifts how value is distributed, channeling the returns of participants' collective relational activity to the corporations that record and mine the data it generates.

Capture by corporate brokers has become more common since the 1980s alongside three transformations that have reshaped market intermediation: the turn to finance, which expanded the share of economic activity routed through specialized intermediaries (Carruthers 2015; Krippner 2011); the digital turn, which dramatically lowered the cost of accumulating, storing, and analyzing the data that brokerage generates while also expanding the demand for predictive analytics (Cohen 2019; Gandy 1993); and the rise of platform capitalism, which produced multi-sided market operators that own the relational infrastructure of matching while monetizing the data it generates (Sadowski 2020; Viljoen, Goldenfein, and McGuigan 2021). Transient brokerage is one of the mechanisms that link these transformations together and contributes to a broader shift in how value is extracted from economic activity.

Significant evidence from financial markets shows that corporate brokers that once facilitated matches between others have increasingly become principals, either by capturing the activity they used to intermediate or by monetizing data. The demutualization of stock exchanges is a prime example. As late as the mid-1990s, almost all major global exchanges operated as member-owned mutual organizations. By the mid-2000s, a majority had introduced electronic trading systems that allowed them to grant trading access directly to investors, bypassing the services of member firms, and had converted to for-profit shareholder structures (Aggarwal 2002; Petry 2021). For-profit exchanges now derive a growing share of revenue from proprietary data feeds and trading technology (MacKenzie 2021; Pardo-Guerra 2019).

A parallel transformation has taken place in interdealer brokerage for over-the-counter (OTC) markets, where the data divisions of prominent brokers now generate substantially higher operating margins than the broking activities themselves; this is the case, for instance, of the Parameta Solutions data division of TP ICAP, the largest interdealer broker (TP ICAP 2026). In consumer markets, Visa offers another example. Reorganized in 1970 as a member-owned cooperative of issuing banks, Visa operated for decades as a non-profit utility that brokered payment authorizations between cardholders, merchants, and banks (Stearns 2011). Following its 2007 restructuring and 2008 IPO, Visa converted into a for-profit corporation that now derives substantial revenue from data, analytics, and risk solutions services, alongside the network and processing fees generated by its core authorization and clearing activities (Visa Inc. 2024).

VII Conclusion

This article reconceptualizes brokerage as outsourced relational work and explains how repeated matching can produce an informational advantage that a corporate broker may later convert into resource capture or data enclosure. The formal illustration demonstrates one possible pathway through which repeated vicarious relational work can produce informational and structural advantages, and it generates propositions about when those advantages should arise. By pooling observations across clients, the broker learns how both parties' characteristics combine and develops assessments that are particularly valuable when the value of a match depends on complementarity. Those assessments can sustain outsourcing even when principals can reach counterparties themselves. Continued outsourcing connects principals to the broker and can increase its structural prominence. When the broker arranges matches between previously unconnected principals, it also creates direct ties that can weaken that position. The broker can therefore be highly central while doing little bridging.

The very conditions that make brokerage possible and valuable, such as the scarcity of information and the complexity of the matching problem, create opportunities for the broker—particularly the corporate broker—to take control of resources. At the transition point, the broker dismantles the relational package negotiated with its principals and collapses the boundary between *vicarious* and *personal* relational work to pursue its own advantage. It abandons or reconfigures the service-tie configuration that existed and (re)negotiates a new one, premised on the broker's direct ownership and control of formerly brokered resources or the data they generated. The broker can use its assessment capability on its own behalf, for resource capture, or sell that capability to third parties. In either case, the accumulated data can also be mined internally or licensed out to feed proprietary behavioral prediction, classification, and scoring products (Fourcade and Healy 2017, 2024) for use in markets distinct from those in which they originated (Viljoen 2021; Zuboff 2019).

The digital turn expands the scale at which corporate brokers can accumulate and use the information generated through their relational work, while machine learning helps them transform accumulated records into valuable predictions about prospective matches. Control over data matters for the quality of future brokerage services, for the strategic capture of resources, and for the development of business lines in prediction and analytics. Corporate brokers carry information acquired in one role into another.

Changes in the information ecosystem reshape the conditions under which brokerage work is performed. Inside corporate brokers, relational infrastructures that once consisted of internal handbooks, contractual templates, and bureaucratic procedures now incorporate data taxonomies, algorithmic sorting, and interface designs that help them create and administer relational packages in real time and at scale. Digital technology amplifies asymmetries of information and shortens the path from accumulated information to ownership or monetization.

Three main directions warrant future work. First, empirical work should test the propositions developed in this article. Relevant comparisons would include markets in which the complementarity between particular goods or market actors matters more or less, participants and ties turn over at different rates, and brokers have different abilities to record and preserve data about past matches. Second, the resource capture and data enclosure mechanisms are introduced theoretically but not yet formalized. A model that includes the transition to capture could examine when a broker continues matching others and when it instead or additionally starts acting as a principal. Moreover, the present model contains only one broker. A model with competing brokers could examine how competition divides observations among them and shapes their ability to build an enduring advantage. Third, theoretical work should more fully address how digital platforms and algorithmic marketplaces automate vicarious relational work through auction protocols, ranking algorithms, and rating systems. Automation reorganizes, but does not eliminate, vicarious relational work. Operators administer categories, ratings, and default settings that shape how users interact and transact, while also

accumulating information across users. They can leverage this information to acquire and sell resources on their own account, including competing with their clients, or to sell analytics. All these research directions point toward a common set of underlying questions about the impact of the digital turn on brokerage, the institutions that rely on it, and the actors that perform it or benefit from it.

The digital turn has brought about a series of transformations. Relational work is increasingly valued for the data it generates and performed by machines rather than people. The informational asymmetry between brokers and their principals has widened. Existing relational packages are being dismantled to extract value from the information and infrastructures associated with them. These shifts redraw the boundaries on which brokerage rests: between internalized and outsourced relational work, and between vicarious and personal relational work. Brokerage becomes transient when matching on behalf of others becomes secondary to the profitability of the information it generated.

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